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icrosoft entered India in 1990, and since then it has played an important

role in boosting the country's economic growth. As Microsoft India—part of the Redmond, Washington-headquartered Microsoft Corp. that had a market capitalisation of \$2 trillion as of July 7—continues investing in India, there is a huge chance that the country will become a big play globally for the tech giant from a business point of view, says President Anant Maheshwari. In a freewheeling interaction with *Business Today's* Sourav Majumdar and Nidhi Singal, Maheshwari, 49, talks about the adoption of digital transformation by India Inc., the threat landscape, and the way forward. Edited excerpts:

Q: It is the end of the year for Microsoft (the tech giant follows a July-June fiscal year). How has the last year been and what will be the broad agenda going forward?

A: I'll start with where we are for Microsoft globally; we've been on this transformation journey for the past eight years, ever since Satya [Nadella] took charge of the company [as CEO]. It started with the mission of empowering every person, every organisation on the planet to achieve more, and pretty much in the same way, we've been going at it in India. I've been part of the company for nearly six years now. I've seen this first-hand... how we operate to transform and deliver that vision on a daily basis to our customers and partners in the country.

Specifically coming to Microsoft India's performance, we are now on track to complete our fourth best-year-ever in succession... It's not just in terms of financial metrics, in terms of how we're looking at the business, but truly making an impact on the landscape of companies that we work with. Today, we work with almost all of the country's top banks, top IT services, top conglomerates, a large number of unicorns, and

many state government and central government ministries. So, if you look at the landscape as the big markers of the economy in India, very strategic work [is] being done with all of them on the public cloud; we are also driving very good progress in the broader SME and start-up ecosystem.

From a customer landscape point of view, the breadth and the depth of what we are doing give us a lot of satisfaction in achieving our mission. And the partner ecosystem that we have in the country is quite unique... everything we do in the market is through our partner ecosystem. The partner ecosystem for us is not just a... go-to-market channel where we transact with the partner, and the partner transacts with the customer. But more importantly, it's the broader ecosystem with all the big advisories in the country—both global and Indian—that are driving a lot of the solutions that people need rather than pointing [to] products that they might use from a tech perspective. The second bit is the system integrator (SI) network, that is the global SIs from India. All the big IT firms [in India] are creating solutions here that they're taking global. And they are now doing it at a scale which is bigger than many of the global companies. And so I do believe that that's a huge opportunity of India becoming a big play for Microsoft globally from a business point of view, and not just from a talent point of view.

And finally, what excites me the most is the independent software vendor (ISV) ecosystem, which are the B2B SaaS [Software-as-a-Service] companies. It's really a big wave that is happening in India at this point in time and Microsoft is enabling all these B2B ISVs to find customers very quickly for [the] Azure Marketplace globally.

Q: You deal with a host of companies. What is your sense of the digital transformation journey that India has undertaken?

A: We are living in a time that is changing every month because of the pandemic and the way people are now returning back to work or not returning back to work. Every company is finding this solution around what is the real future of work—is that life coming back to normal or not?

We do a Future of Work survey every few months. For India, the Work Trend Index survey [that released in June 2021] found that nearly 74 per cent of people in the country want more flexibility—that means more remote work options—while at the same time 73 per cent